Wellness, "you need to put clothes to your carbs. The best way is to mix it with nutrient-rich foods, like vegetables, lean proteins and healthy fats." That's because when you eat carb-heavy food, your blood glucose (sugar) levels see sharp spikes and crashes, which isn't healthy. However, if you consume carbs with foods that have protein and fat along with fibre, the rate at which carbs are broken down into glucose slows down, which helps maintain a steady blood sugar level.

But why are carbs bad, to begin with? "After you eat, your body breaks carbs into sugar, releasing energy," says Ritika Samaddar, head of nutrition at Max Super Speciality Hospital in Delhi. "How fast this is done is measured by something called the glycaemic index. Wheat and rice have a high glycaemic index, which could lead to high sugar levels in the blood apart from fats, especially if a person has a sedentary lifestyle, as most urban Indians do."

In 2019, a survey by the Department of Food and Nutrition at Lady Irwin College in Delhi identified tea, chapati, milk (as beverage), boiled rice and biscuits as the top five most frequently consumed food items. Three of these—chapati, rice and biscuits—are loaded with carbs, with some added sugar and fat in biscuits. A six-inch chapati, for instance, contains around 15 gm of carbs, 3 gm protein, 0.4 gm fat and 71 calories. The average amount of carbs recommended for those who want to lose weight is as low as 30 gm in some low-carb diets, and the average calorie content around 1,200. The trick then is to lower the overall glycaemic index of your intake.

The Magic of Millets

For long rendered the poor cousins, Indian millets, such as ragi, bajra, jowar, amaranth and kodo, are now having their moment in the sun, with the government declaring 2023 the year of the millets. "Millets have long been part of the Indian diet," says Swati Bhushan, a clinical nutritionist at Fortis Hiranandani in Mumbai. They fell out of favour as wheat became



MANDAR DEODHAR

> **"If you enjoy white rice, you must put clothes to your carbs. Mix it with nutrient-rich foods like veggies, lean protein and healthy fats"**
>
> **-NEHA SAHAYA**
> *Nutrition consultant and founder, Neha Sahaya Wellness*

